

minicomputers in the PDP and the VAX series, which were much in use among scientists and engineers in the 1970s and 1980s. Some notable products from the DEC stables included the PDP-8 (in 1963, which was the first minicomputer), the PDP-11 (which supported the then-new UNIX), and the VAX (the first 32-bit minicomputer). It was also largely influential in making the Ethernet standard commercially successful. In the 1980s it lost out to newer competitors and was ultimately sold out to Compaq.



The PDP-1 microcomputer (a front-right side view)

Enlarge Your...

The first spam message was sent by a DEC employee in 1979 over the ARPANET. About 400 people received the message.

The Not-so-mini Mini

The minicomputer is a now-obsolete class of computer, which was positioned between mainframes and personal computers. This class, which evolved in the 60s, had its own hardware and operating systems, though computers in the class were just bigger and more powerful versions of the personal computer. This category died out in the 1980s with the advent of cheaper and more powerful hardware.